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### The Rehearsal or The Hyperreal?

HBO's *The Rehearsal*, created by and starring Nathan Fielder, is a docu-comedy series surrounding Fielder's fascination with using role-play to explore humans' desire to control their future. Fielder does this through elaborate role-play; in one episode, he creates an exact functional replica of a Williamsburg bar, The Alligator Lounge, along with actors and extras to help a man rehearse a confession to his bar-trivia teammate. Fielder tries his best to create an accurate simulation of the events that may occur on confession day but, in the process, manipulates the outcome of a trivia game by discreetly planting all the answers in the man's head. While the real confession goes well for the man, the outcome was manipulated by Nathan planting all of the night's trivia answers in the man's mind a week before, creating an ideal scenario that likely would not have transpired if Nathan had not have been involved. Jean Baudrillard, a philosopher deeply interested in simulation and its effects on human thought, coined a term used to describe simulations that become better or more real than reality itself: hyperreality. Supporting Baudrillard's belief that simulation threatens the existence of reality, Nathan Fielder's largest rehearsal in the series, a rehearsal of parenthood, exemplifies a simulation's ability to replace reality and become hyperreal.

Attempting to create a trial-run simulation of parenthood for a woman named Angela, Nathan Fielder constructs her a hyperreal through the elimination of large passages of time and the swapping out of multiple child actors to play her child, Adam. Nathan Fielder's elaborate

scheme to simulate motherhood had child actors of increasing ages regularly swapped out to mimic Adam's stages of childhood. While Angela is obviously not a real mother to these children, the simulation does help her realize issues she may have in real motherhood, such as finding a romantic partner willing to co-parent - her date leaves after hearing a robotic baby cry during the night. Angela, nonetheless continues the process and lives her life in this rehearsal for a couple of months. In episode five of the series, "Apocalypso", we find out that when Nathan leaves Angela alone with the Adams, she references them by their real names, and goofs off around the house as if Adam was not there. Angela is living a "life of motherhood" without actually having to parent. She has no stake in Adam's future because the children all go back to their real families and lives after spending just a few hours a day with Angela. The reality of her trial motherhood, 18 years of a child's life condensed into a couple months, her actions having little consequence on who these children will grow up to be in the real world, and living in her dream house, is objectively better than the real hardships of motherhood. Yet, Angela continues to live within the experiment and take advantage of her life there until she is confronted by her lack of commitment to the process. When confronted, she seems to truly believe that she had been navigating the hardships of motherhood, "I navigated through a lot of situations that, you know, were difficult and uncertain, and I wasn't given a lot of direction... I've never done this before" (*The Rehearsal*, Season 1, Episode 5). Soon after this, Angela decides she wants this rehearsal to come to an expedited close. It isn't until she is confronted with the reality of her actions that she chooses to abandon this run of motherhood. Nathan's plan was to give Angela the tools to try being a mother, an experience both of them have never had before. Because of the "lack of direction" on how to be a mother, Angela essentially created her own reality of what motherhood looks like using the environment given to her. Baudrillard's description of the

hyperreal can effectively be used to describe Angela's experience as a "mother": "Simulation is no longer that of a territory, a referential being or a substance. It is the generation by models of a real without origin or reality: a hyperreal" (Baudrillard, 2). Not only does Angela mention her lack of given direction, but also, the rehearsal offered no guidelines on motherhood. The simulation is the reality of motherhood to Angela and the lack of groundedness in reality of this lifestyle makes it the reality she wants to accept and continue living in. Because the simulation was designed specifically for her to take on the role of a mother, Angela would see her life in the rehearsal's house to be the life of motherhood regardless of how true to reality it is; the role of mother was given to her whether or not she acted like one.

Furthermore, Fielder's simulation acting as a hyperreal provides an explanation as to why the reality of one of the child actors, Remy, was uniquely distorted. Midway through the series, Fielder decided to play the role of a father in the simulation to confront his own questions about parenthood, and, after Angela decides to leave the experiment, is the only parent left in his simulation. In the sixth and final episode, "Pretend Daddy", Remy, who played six year old Adam, begins to cry and refuses to leave and change out of his character's clothes after his final day on set. We find out that Remy does not have a father figure in his life. Using Baudrillard's terms, Remy does not have a referential father figure in his life, therefore, Nathan simulating Remy's father is not a simulation to Remy - it is hyperreal. Even as Nathan visit's Remy's home to explain that the simulation was pretend, Remy proceeds to say, "I was just playing with Daddy," in protest to his mother restraining him from wiggling towards Nathan (*The Rehearsal*, Episode 6). Soon after Remy's mother declares that Nathan is not his dad, Remy, on the verge of tears, utters, "I just want to stay with him" (*The Rehearsal*, Episode 6). Even though Remy was no longer participating in the simulation and was physically away from the site of the hyperreal,

the notion that Nathan is his father completely altered what reality was to him. Regardless of what Nathan or Remy's mother told him was real, Remy is still living in a reality where Nathan loves him as a son. Remembering that the hyperreal is the last phase of Baudrillard's concept of the phases of simulacra, Nathan as "Daddy" can also be described as a simulacrum to Remy. To introduce the section of his text titled "The Precession of Simulacra", Baudrillard quotes *Ecclesiastes*: "The simulacrum is never that which conceals the truth – it is the truth which conceals that there is none. The simulacrum is true" (Baudrillard, 1). Remy and Nathan's relationship matches this well; Remy has no true father that Nathan is replacing or concealing, therefore Nathan conceals the fact that Remy is fatherless and becomes Remy's true image of a father.

One criticism of Remy's situation in *The Rehearsal* when the show first started streaming was that the use of child actor's was problematic because of how impressionable young kids can be. This raises the question, would Remy be as affected by the hyperreal if he were older, and does age and therefore, a greater understanding of one's own life and the world around them, make people less susceptible to hyperreality replacing their reality? While a fatherless adult playing Nathan's son may not believe that Nathan is his true father, I suspect that the distress that Remy felt as he had to leave Nathan may remain; this theoretical man's lack of experience with feeling what fatherly love feels like means he has no referential to deny or create a distinction between simulated or real fatherly love. Thinking about adults that can get sucked into a hyperreality, I'm immediately reminded of cults like Heaven's Gate. When a religion or an ideology is not the subversion of a truth you already know, but the introduction of a completely novel idea, like your consciousness being able to be transported by aliens aboard a spacecraft, its power to replace or alter your reality heightens. Escaping hyperreality, as it was with Remy,

seems extremely difficult and makes me question how much of my reality, by way of misinformation, persuasion, or simply the limited amount of environments I've been exposed to, is hyperreal.

Works Cited

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